

Patient Elopement and Missing Patient Response

Policy Number	POL-SEC-010	Owner / Department	Security / Nursing / Emergency Management
Effective Date	2023-10-01	Version	2.4
Last Revised	2026-02-05	Next Review	2028-02-05
Approved By	Patient Safety & Quality Committee	Applies To	All units; coordinated with Security and the Administrator-on-Call

1. Purpose

To standardize the response when a patient who lacks the capacity to make a safe decision to leave, or who is at risk to self or others, is missing from the care area.

2. Definitions

- **Elopement** — a patient who is unsafe to be left unsupervised leaves the unit or facility without staff knowledge.
- **Missing patient** — a patient cannot be located within the care area.
- **Code Green** — the facility overhead alert for an elopement / missing at-risk patient.

3. Immediate Response

1. Perform a rapid search of the immediate area (room, bathroom, unit).
2. Notify the charge nurse and Security immediately with the patient's name, description, last-known location, and time last seen.
3. Initiate an overhead Code Green and notify the Administrator-on-Call; Security coordinates a facility and grounds search.
4. Notify the attending provider and, as appropriate, the patient's family and law enforcement.
5. File an event report per POL-RM-013; a missing at-risk patient is at least SEV-2 and is SEV-1 if the patient is harmed or is a danger to self/others.

4. References

- The Joint Commission, Environment of Care and Emergency Management standards.
- Facility Emergency Operations Plan — overhead code standards.
- Related: POL-RM-013 (severity & reporting).